

ENTERPRISE ARCHITECTURE

STRATEGY PLAYBOOK

How EA Creates Strategy from Pitch to Retire

A step-by-step operational playbook defining the plays, RACI responsibilities, decision criteria, common pitfalls, and success patterns for each stage of the Enterprise Architecture lifecycle. Designed for EA practitioners, Solution Architects, and Architecture Review Boards.

1. PITCH	2. APPROVE	3. DESIGN	4. BUILD	5. OPERATE	6. REVIEW	7. RETIRE
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EA Practice

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How to Read This Playbook

Each stage contains: the strategic purpose of that phase, the key plays (actions the EA team must run), a RACI matrix clarifying who does what, typical pitfalls to avoid, and the specific gate criteria that must be satisfied before the next stage begins.

R — Responsible	The person who does the work. There should be exactly one R per task.
A — Accountable	The person who is ultimately answerable. Signs off. One A per task.
C — Consulted	Subject matter experts who provide input. Two-way communication.
I — Informed	Stakeholders kept up to date. One-way communication only.

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Stage 1: Pitch / Demand

The idea enters the funnel. EA shapes it before money is committed.

■ 1–3 weeks

Strategic Purpose

At the Pitch stage, the EA's job is to prevent expensive mistakes before they happen. Most failed initiatives fail not in delivery but in framing. EA brings rigour to the idea by validating it against the current landscape, existing capabilities, and strategic priorities — transforming an informal request into a structured architecture intake that the governance process can act on.

The Key Plays

Play 1: Run the Landscape Assessment

- Pull the current application portfolio and search for existing capabilities that match the need
- Cross-reference the architecture roadmap for in-flight initiatives that could satisfy the request
- Identify integration touchpoints and data domain ownership relevant to the idea
- Document your findings in the Architecture Intake Assessment (AIA) — 1–2 pages max

Play 2: Frame the Build / Buy / Reuse Decision

- Define the three options explicitly: Build (custom dev), Buy (COTS/SaaS), Reuse (extend existing)
- Score each option on: strategic fit, cost, speed to value, risk, and technical alignment
- Make a provisional recommendation in the AIA — this will be validated at the ARB
- Flag any technology choices that are outside the approved technology radar

RACI — Stage 1: Pitch

Task / Decision	Ent. Architect	Sol. Architect	ARB	Bus. Owner	Delivery Lead
Receive and log the intake request		I	I		-
Conduct landscape and portfolio assessment	R	C	I	I	-
Frame build/buy/reuse options			I		-
Produce Architecture Intake Assessment	R	C	I	A	-
Approve AIA and recommend to ARB		-			-

PLAYBOOK TIP

Always check the vendor contract register before recommending a 'buy' — the organisation may already be paying for a licence that covers the need.

WATCH OUT

Watch out: Sponsors often arrive with a pre-chosen solution. Your job at Pitch is to validate the problem, not rubber-stamp the solution.

■ GATE: Architecture Intake Gate

Output: Signed Architecture Intake Assessment. Sponsor confirmed. Strategic theme mapped.

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Stage 2: Approve / Govern

ARB validates the business case and grants conditional investment approval.

■ 1–2 weeks

Strategic Purpose

The Approve stage is the EA's most powerful governance lever. The ARB acts as the quality gate that prevents technical debt accumulation, architectural sprawl, and misaligned investment. The EA must ensure that every approval is conditional on standards compliance — not a rubber stamp based on business pressure.

The Key Plays

Play 3: Conduct the Architecture Standards Review

- Validate proposed technology stack against the Technology Radar (Adopt / Trial / Hold / Retire)
- Confirm integration approach: REST API, event-driven, batch, or point-to-point
- Verify cloud deployment model aligns with the Cloud Adoption Framework
- Confirm security architecture scope: zero trust posture, encryption, IAM approach

Play 4: Run the ARB and Issue the ADR

- Circulate ARB pack (AIA + options analysis + standards review) 5 business days in advance
- Present to ARB: problem, options, recommendation, conditions, risks
- Record ARB decision: Approve / Approve with Conditions / Defer / Reject
- Publish Architecture Decision Record (ADR) with rationale, constraints, and review date
- Assign named Solution Architect before closing the gate

RACI — Stage 2: Approve

Task / Decision	Ent. Architect	Sol. Architect	ARB	Bus. Owner	Delivery Lead
Prepare ARB submission pack			I		-
Present to ARB	R	C	A	I	-
Record and publish ARB decision		-		I	-
Issue Architecture Decision Record	R	-	A	I	-
Assign Solution Architect			I	I	-

- PLAYBOOK TIP

Conditions on ARB approvals must have named owners and resolution dates. A condition without an owner is not a condition — it is deferred risk.
- WATCH OUT

Watch out: Business pressure to 'just approve it' is highest here. An EA who approves to avoid conflict is not doing their job.

■ **GATE: ARB Architecture Approval Gate**

Output: Signed ARB Decision Record. ADR published.
Solution Architect assigned.

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Stage 3: Design

Target state architecture is defined. Delivery guardrails are established.

■ 2–6 weeks

Strategic Purpose

Design is where abstraction becomes reality. The EA, working with the assigned Solution Architect, translates the approved concept into a technical blueprint that delivery teams can execute. The output must be precise enough to prevent drift, but flexible enough to allow good engineering decisions within guardrails.

The Key Plays

Play 5: Produce the Solution Architecture Document (SAD)

- Define system context (C4 Level 1): boundaries, actors, and external systems
- Define container/component diagrams for all new or significantly modified systems
- Document all integration contracts: API specs (OpenAPI), event schemas, data formats
- Map data flows and define data ownership, classification (PII/sensitive/public)
- Define all Non-Functional Requirements: availability, performance, scalability, RTO/RPO

Play 6: Publish the Architecture Guardrails Document

- List approved technology versions and permitted third-party libraries
- Define mandatory patterns: authentication, error handling, logging, API versioning
- Specify architecture compliance checkpoints within the delivery schedule
- Define architecture fitness functions where automated compliance checking applies
- Obtain peer review of SAD from at least one other EA before submission

RACI — Stage 3: Design

Task / Decision	Ent. Architect	Sol. Architect	ARB	Bus. Owner	Delivery Lead
Produce Solution Architecture Document			I	I	I
NFR definition and validation	C	R	I	C	C
Peer review of SAD			I	I	-
ARB review and SAD sign-off	A	R	R	I	I
Publish architecture guardrails			I	I	

■

PLAYBOOK

TIP

NFRs defined here are legally binding for the delivery team. If availability is set at 99.9%, the infrastructure must be designed and costed to deliver it.

■ WATCH OUT	Watch out: SADs that are too prescriptive stifle good engineering. Define the what and the why — not always the how.
■ GATE: Solution Architecture Sign-off Gate	Output: Peer-reviewed SAD. ARB chair approved. Guardrails document published.

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Stage 4: Build / Deliver

Delivery teams build. EA governs compliance and manages architecture drift.

■ Varies (weeks to months)

Strategic Purpose

Build is where the EA transitions from author to guardian. The delivery team executes; the EA's role is to ensure what gets built matches what was approved — not by micromanaging engineers, but by running structured compliance touchpoints that catch drift early before it becomes expensive or irreversible.

The Key Plays

Play 7: Run the 30% and 70% Architecture Reviews

- At 30%: review structural decisions — are the right systems being built in the right way?
- At 70%: review implementation fidelity — is the SAD being followed? Are integrations compliant?
- Log all deviations from the SAD as formal architecture exceptions with justification
- Approve minor deviations; escalate significant ones to the ARB

Play 8: Run the Pre-Production Architecture Sign-Off

- Verify deployed architecture matches approved SAD — check for configuration drift
- Confirm NFR testing completed: load test results, failover test, DR drill
- Validate security controls: penetration test or DAST scan completed
- Confirm observability stack is live: logging, metrics, alerts, distributed tracing
- Update application portfolio inventory with production system details

RACI — Stage 4: Build

Task / Decision	Ent. Architect	Sol. Architect	ARB	Bus. Owner	Delivery Lead
Architecture review at 30% milestone			I	I	
Architecture review at 70% milestone	A	R	I	I	C
Approve/escalate architecture exceptions				I	I
Pre-production compliance sign-off	A	R	C	I	I
Update application portfolio inventory			I	I	

- PLAYBOOK TIP

The 30% review is your most cost-effective intervention. Catching a structural mistake here saves 10x the cost of fixing it at 90%.
- WATCH OUT

Watch out: 'We'll fix it post-launch' is the most common phrase that creates permanent technical debt. Hold the gate firmly.

■ GATE: Architecture Compliance Gate (Pre-Production)	Output: Signed compliance sign-off. NFR tests passed. Observability confirmed.
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Stage 5: Operate / Run

The asset is live. EA monitors portfolio health and manages standards compliance.

Ongoing
(quarterly reviews)

Strategic Purpose

Operate is the longest and most underappreciated stage. Systems decay from the moment they go live — through technology obsolescence, integration drift, and accumulating exceptions. The EA's role is to maintain portfolio hygiene through regular, systematic monitoring that catches issues before they become crises.

The Key Plays

Play 9: Maintain the Application Portfolio

- Review portfolio metadata quarterly: ownership, criticality tier, data classification
- Track all technology end-of-life dates — flag any component within 18 months of EOL
- Monitor the architecture exceptions register — exceptions without resolution dates become permanent debt
- Maintain integration dependency map as systems evolve

Play 10: Run the Quarterly Compliance Review

- Review standards compliance dashboard: security patch levels, API versions, EOL components
- Review integration health metrics: error rates, latency trends, SLA performance
- Review active architecture exceptions: resolve, extend, or escalate each one
- Produce quarterly EA health summary for the CTO/CIO with RAG status per domain

RACI — Stage 5: Operate

Task / Decision	Ent. Architect	Sol. Architect	ARB	Bus. Owner	Delivery Lead
Quarterly portfolio metadata review			I	I	
Technology EOL monitoring and flagging	R	I	I	I	C
Architecture exceptions management			I	I	
Quarterly compliance review report	R	I	A	I	I
Escalation of critical compliance failures		I			I

PLAYBOOK TIP Set automated alerts for technology EOL dates at 24, 18, and 12 months. Manual tracking always misses items.

WATCH OUT Watch out: 'Temporary' exceptions that are never resolved. Every exception must have a named owner and a target resolution date.

■ **GATE: Annual Portfolio Health Review**

Output: Annual portfolio health report. All exceptions reviewed.
EOL risks escalated.

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Stage 6: Review / Optimise

Annual rationalisation. Each asset is scored and a lifecycle disposition is made.

■ Annual cycle
(4–6 weeks)

Strategic Purpose

Review is the EA's portfolio strategy engine. Application rationalisation is the primary EA operational metric. It prevents the portfolio from growing unchecked and creates the strategic intelligence needed to direct future investment. Every system must earn its place in the portfolio annually.

The Key Plays

Play 11: Run the Application Rationalisation Assessment

- Score each system on Business Value (1–5): usage, strategic fit, revenue impact, regulatory necessity
- Score each system on Technical Health (1–5): maintainability, security, support status, currency
- Plot on the EA Value/Health 2x2 matrix to determine quadrant
- Determine disposition: Retain / Invest / Migrate / Consolidate / Retire
- Validate disposition with the business owner before finalising

Play 12: Disposition Matrix — What Each Quadrant Means

- High Value + High Health = RETAIN — maintain current investment, monitor annually
- High Value + Low Health = INVEST — prioritise modernisation; technical debt is a business risk
- Low Value + High Health = CONSOLIDATE/MIGRATE — find a better home for the capability
- Low Value + Low Health = RETIRE — decommission; cost of ownership exceeds business return

RACI — Stage 6: Review

Task / Decision	Ent. Architect	Sol. Architect	ARB	Bus. Owner	Delivery Lead
Application scoring (value + health)			I		
2x2 matrix analysis and disposition	R	C	I	C	-
Business owner validation of disposition		I	I		-
Approve rationalisation decisions	A	I	R	C	-
Update roadmap with rationalisation outputs		I	I	I	-

PLAYBOOK TIP

The business value score must be validated with the business owner. Technical health is EA's domain; business value is shared ownership.

WATCH OUT

Watch out: Business owners will always score their system's value higher. Use usage data, integration counts, and revenue attribution to anchor the conversation.

■ **GATE: Annual Rationalisation Decision Gate**

Output: Signed rationalisation decisions. Updated roadmap. Retire candidates identified.

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Stage 7: Retire / Decommission Controlled shutdown.**Dependencies resolved. Data migrated. Contracts closed.**■ 3–12 months
depending on
complexity**Strategic Purpose**

Retirement is the most underestimated stage in the lifecycle. Organisations often focus on building new capabilities while neglecting the controlled shutdown of old ones. Poor decommission practice creates orphaned integrations, data compliance risks, and zombie systems that keep drawing run cost long after they should have been switched off. The EA must treat every retirement as a formal project.

The Key Plays**Play 13: Dependency Resolution**

- Produce the full dependency map: every upstream producer and downstream consumer
- Notify all dependent teams with minimum 90-day decommission notice
- Confirm every integration has a migration path — no orphaned consumers at switch-off
- Validate replacement system can handle the redirected load before cutover

Play 14: Data, Commercial & Portfolio Close-Out

- Define and execute data disposition: archive, migrate, or delete per regulatory requirements
- Confirm GDPR / legal hold requirements with Legal before any data deletion
- Issue formal contract termination notice to all vendors (check notice periods: 30–90 days)
- Decommission all infrastructure: servers, VMs, cloud resources, DNS, firewall rules
- Remove system from all access control lists, identity directories, and monitoring
- Archive all documentation (SAD, ADRs, runbooks) for minimum 7 years
- Remove from application portfolio. Update all architecture diagrams. Issue decommission certificate.

RACI — Stage 7: Retire

Task / Decision	Ent. Architect	Sol. Architect	ARB	Bus. Owner	Delivery Lead
Produce full dependency map			I	I	
Notify dependent teams (90-day notice)	R	C	I	A	C
Data disposition planning			I		I
Contract and vendor termination	I	I	I	A	R
Infrastructure decommission			I	I	
Portfolio and documentation close-out	R	C	A	I	I

■
PLAYBOOK
TIP

Run a lessons-learned session after every major decommission. Insights on dependency discovery and data migration improve every future retirement.

■ WATCH
OUT

Watch out: Access not removed is an immediate security and audit finding. Build access removal into the decommission runbook as a mandatory last step.

■ GATE: Decommission Completion Gate

Output: Decommission certificate signed by EA, Platform Owner, Legal, and Business Owner.